



Saurabh Kumar in office

India in a technical role. If at all Kumar was to change anything from his early days, he would like to stop being an introvert.

R.K. Laxman, Amitabh Bachchan, and Cricket

The first time Kumar got any access to a television set was when he was seventeen years of age. His family did not own a TV before that. Kumar recalls that he used to wait for the newspaper every day to see the cartoons made by R.K. Laxman. Though he was also fond of other cartoon series like Asterix, R.K. Laxman continues to remain his favourite. Kumar stopped watching movies in 1990 after he stopped liking the work of his favourite actor Amitabh Bachchan.

"I was seventeen when we got our first TV, so there was no chance of watching cartoons or anything else on TV before that. Then I got admitted to IIT Kanpur and was never able

to find time for watching anything on TV. But I was into a lot of reading," says Kumar.

Kumar, in fact, is into lot of reading since his childhood. He was a fond reader of the work by Alistair Mclean and Sydney Sheldon till his ninth standard in school. He, however, started giving more time to preparation for entrance exams for IIT after the tenth standard. Allahabad, as a city, was not particularly known for any kind of entrance exam coaching back in the 1980s, and most of the preparation that Kumar did was through school and on his own.

"The eleventh and twelfth standards were only about studies and nothing else. The only recreational activity that I did in these classes was playing cricket," says Kumar. His favourite cricketers till date happen to be England's David Gower and India's Sunil Gavaskar.

He recalls that the syllabus at IIT

did not leave any room to take up reading any other kind of books. But once he started pursuing his masters in Japan, he was able to find more time for reading. What caught his attention in books and content? Well, anything and everything around environment and its sustainability!

Jared Diamond's work in the book titled 'Collapse: How Societies Choose to Fail or Succeed' has moved him a lot and allowed him to see what happens in the world with a new perspective. This book is known for its coverage of economic and environmental disasters.

"Jared Diamond in this book talks about the Amazon Forest. A phrase that he uses in the book is Landscape Amnesia. He explains how a part of the forest goes on to be completely degraded in just ten years of time, damaged in a way that it has almost become impossible to replenish it. Such things leading to collapse is all that book is about," Kumar explains about the book.

The greatest lesson that this book taught him is that rather than looking at everyday things, we as humans should pay close attention to what should be preserved and when it should be preserved. The book tells great tales of why civilisations fail due to landscape amnesia. This is where I could connect the dots between him trying super hard to make EESL a hit in India and beyond. Kumar seems greatly concerned about saving energy because it, in turn, saves the environment.

More proof of his concern for environment comes through another book and the documentary based on the book, which is close to his heart. The name of this book is 'Guns, Germs and Steel.' BBC made the documentary based on this book authored by Jared Diamond. The book is a portrayal of the Latin American history. It tells how Europeans were able to take control of the Latin American region by using guns, germs (biological warfare!), and steel.

Kumar's favourite sports now happen to be tennis and golf. Tennis because it gives him an hour away from work every morning, and golf is something that he wants to pursue more after he retires. He, like some